Why Right and Wrong Have No Place in Your Relationship

One of the biggest communication traps couples fall into is the idea that there is a singular, objective reality they both should see the same way. When disagreements happen, the natural impulse is to argue about *who is right* — as if one of you has the "correct" version of reality and the other just needs to be convinced.

But here's the truth: **The Map is Not the Territory.**

The world itself — the objective territory — is real. But our experience of it is shaped by our personal map: the meaning we assign to what happens, the emotions it stirs up, and the stories we tell ourselves about it. And no two maps are identical.

So when you and your partner argue, you're not really disagreeing about the territory. You're arguing over maps. And if you approach communication from the assumption that your map is *the* correct one, you're setting yourself up for conflict, disconnection, and frustration.

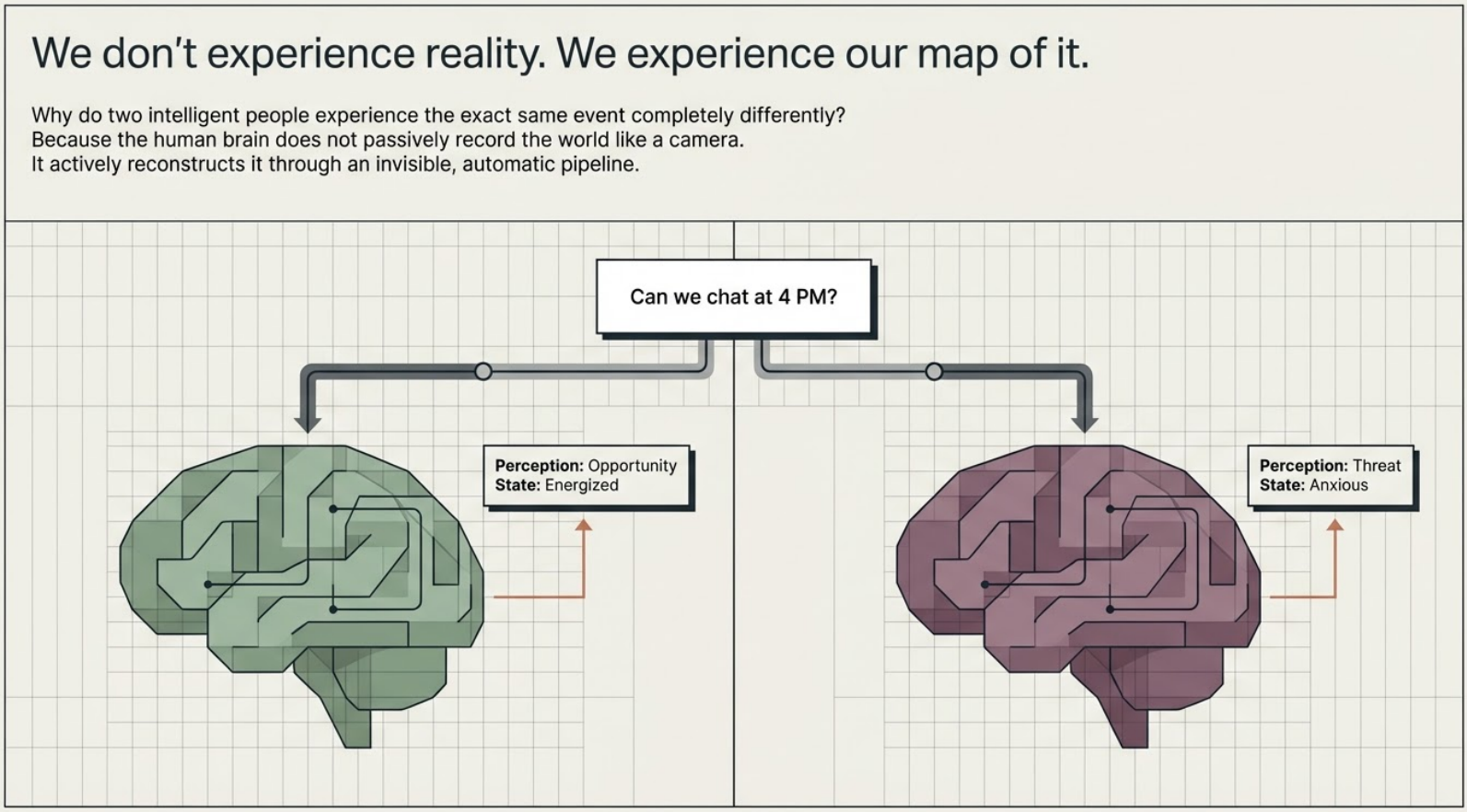
Instead, the key to real understanding is this:

- Hold your map with *humility.*
- *Listen to your partner's map with curiosity.*

What is MAPSS?

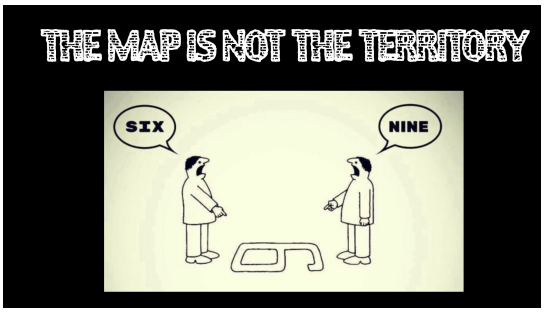
To make this clearer, I break our individual maps down into **MAPSS**, which stands for:

- **Mind:** What your attention locks onto. How your brain filters incoming information through cognitive bias, past experience, and what it has been trained to look for.
- **Attribution:** The meaning you assign to what happened. Who's at fault, what it means, what's "really going on."
- **Perspective:** The emotional and psychological state you were already in when the moment hit.
- **Sentiment:** The primary emotion running underneath the one you showed — often fear, shame, sadness, grief, or longing. The feeling driving the reaction, not the reaction itself.
- **Story:** The personal narrative you build from these elements. How this moment fits into the larger story you tell about yourself, your partner, and the relationship.



“We are never merely reacting to what happens or doesn’t happen, to what is said or left unsaid. We are reacting to the meaning we assign these things.”

— Christian J. Charette



Let’s see this in action:

Example: The Text Message Fight

Let’s say your partner doesn’t respond to your text for hours.

The territory (objective reality): They didn’t text back for four hours. That’s all we actually know.

Your map might look like this:

- **Mind:** Your attention locks onto the silence. Past experiences of feeling ignored or rejected surface quickly.
- **Attribution:** “They don’t care enough to respond.”
- **Perspective:** You’re already stressed from work and running low on bandwidth.
- **Sentiment:** Underneath the anger, fear of not mattering.
- **Story:** “I always have to chase them for attention. I’m the only one who cares in this relationship.”

By the time they do respond, you’re already emotionally charged. You snap at them, or you go cold and distant. And now they react — not to the late response, but to your tone. Suddenly, it’s a full-blown argument.

But let’s look at their map.

- **Mind:** Their attention was consumed by deep focus at work. They lost track of time entirely.
- **Attribution:** They assume you know they’re busy and don’t register the delay as meaningful.
- **Perspective:** They’re overwhelmed with tasks and running on fumes.
- **Sentiment:** Mild exhaustion with a thread of confusion when your tone shifts.
- **Story:** “I’ve had a long day. Why are they mad at me out of nowhere?”

Neither of you is wrong. You're just living inside different maps.

How the Brain Makes Maps

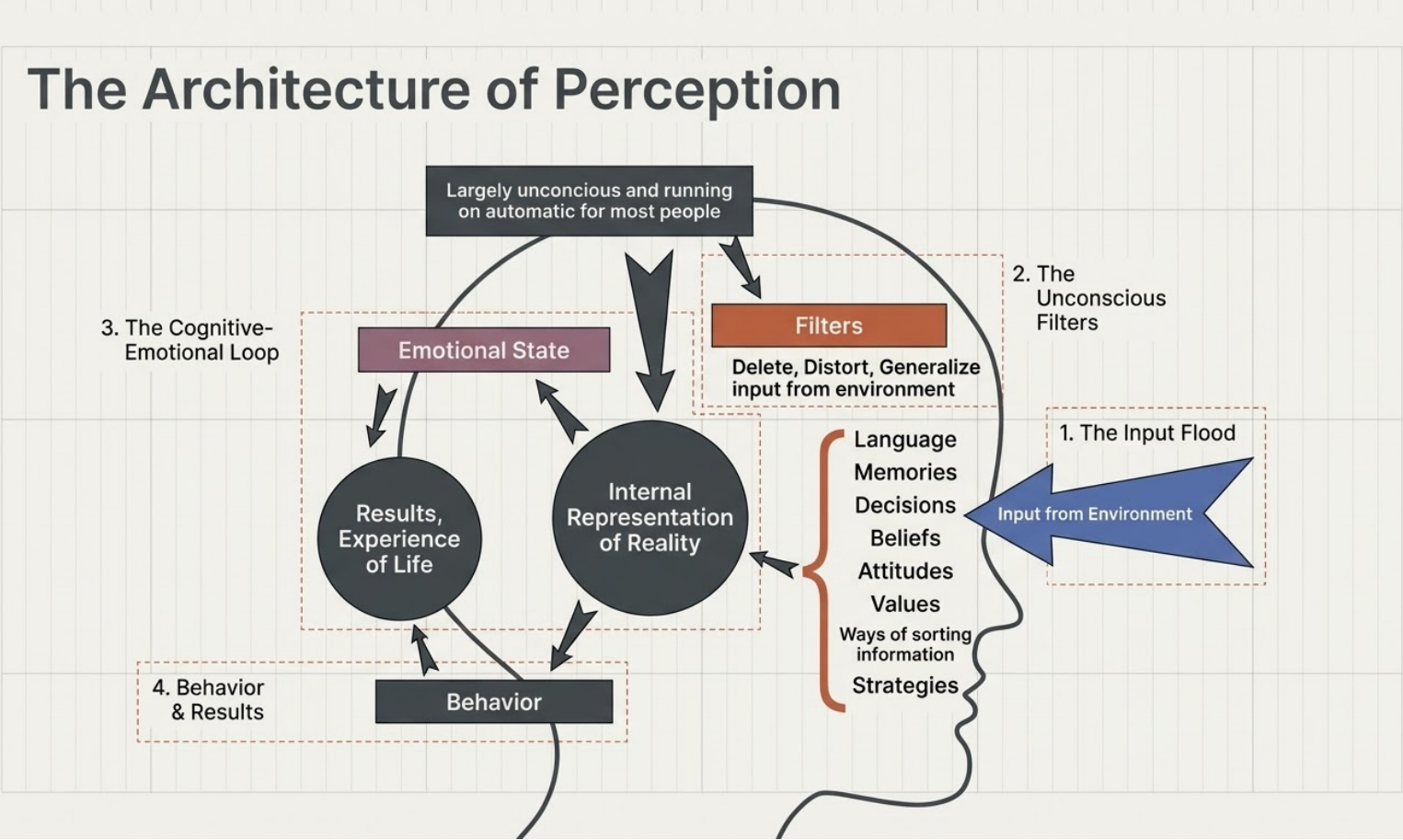
From a neuroscience perspective, your brain is a meaning-making machine. It's constantly filtering reality through confirmation bias, which means you automatically seek out information that supports what you already believe.

Your limbic system (emotional brain) reacts first — before your prefrontal cortex (rational brain) has a chance to slow things down. If past experiences have wired you to expect rejection, your brain primes you to see it, even when it's not there. This is why our maps feel so real. They're shaped by years of emotional conditioning, personal history, and unconscious biases.

But once you understand that you are not reacting to reality — you are reacting to your map of reality — you gain power over how you respond.

> *"If you are distressed by anything external, it is not the thing itself that troubles you, but your judgment about it. And it is in your power to wipe out that judgment now."*
>
> **— Marcus Aurelius (Meditations, 8.47)**

The Unreliable Narrator: How Your Brain Warps Reality



The diagram above illustrates how we construct our internal map of reality. The world doesn't come to us raw — we filter it. Four zones define the architecture: **(1) The Input Flood** — the environment constantly sending signals into the system; **(2) The Unconscious Filters** — language, memories, decisions, beliefs, attitudes, values, and strategies that delete, distort, and generalize input; **(3) The Cognitive-Emotional Loop** — the internal representation of reality and the emotional state feeding each other in real time; and **(4) Behavior & Results** — what you do and the life you experience as a consequence.

This process is largely **unconscious and automatic** for most people, meaning we are constantly *interpreting* reality rather than simply perceiving it.

This is why **memory is unreliable**, why two people can experience the same event differently, and why relationships suffer when we assume our perception is an objective truth rather than a subjective map.

Memory is Not a Video Recorder — It's a Reconstruction

One of the most common misconceptions is that memory works like a video recorder — that our past experiences are stored accurately and can be played back as they happened. But neuroscience has shown that **memory is a reconstruction, not a replay**. Each time we recall a memory, we modify it based on current emotions, biases, and new experiences. This means that every time you *remember* an event, you're not recalling the original event — you're recalling the last time you remembered it.

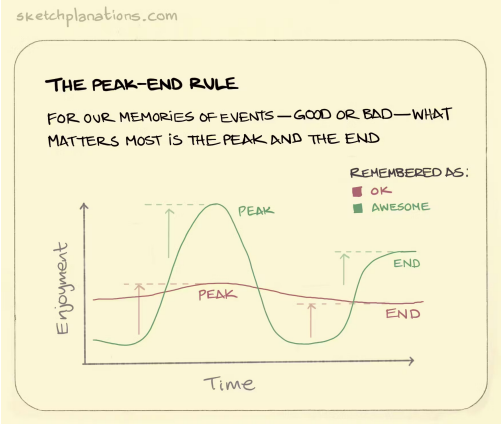
The Science of Memory Distortion

Elizabeth Loftus' research on false memories (Loftus & Palmer, 1974) showed how **leading questions can alter memory.** In her famous study, participants watched a video of a car accident. When asked how fast the cars were going when they "smashed" into each other, they reported significantly higher speeds and even recalled broken glass that wasn't there — just because of the word "smashed."

Daniel Kahneman's peak-end rule explains how we remember **experiences based on their peak emotional moments and how they ended** rather than the full event. This is why a single heated argument at the end of a vacation can distort your memory of the whole trip.

Cold Water Immersion Study (1993): In a seminal experiment, participants underwent two different cold-water experiences:

- **Short Trial:** Submerging a hand in 14°C (57°F) water for 60 seconds.
- **Long Trial:** Submerging a hand in 14°C water for 60 seconds, followed by an additional 30 seconds as the water temperature was gradually raised to 15°C (59°F).



Despite the longer exposure in the second trial, participants reported it as less unpleasant due to the slightly warmer ending. When given a choice, many preferred to repeat the longer trial, illustrating that the less painful end influenced their memory of the experience more than the total duration of discomfort.

Hippocampal malleability: The **hippocampus**, which plays a major role in forming and retrieving memories, is constantly reshaping how we recall past events. The brain **fills in gaps** and **creates details that weren't there.**

Example: If you recall a childhood vacation repeatedly, small details (like the weather or what someone said) may **change** over time, especially if others tell stories about it that influence your own memory.

Example: Two people in the same argument may later **remember** it differently based on how emotionally triggered they were at the time.

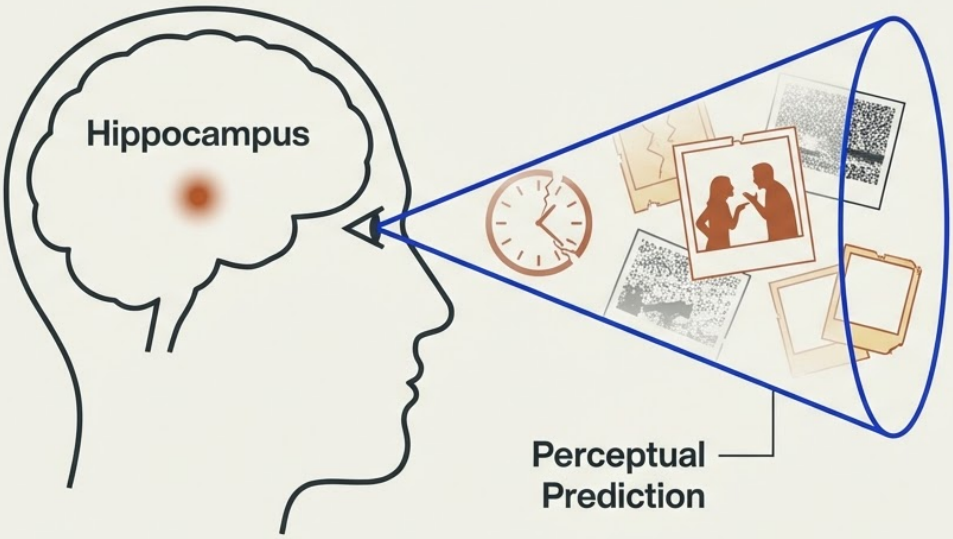
Example: A witness to an accident may recall seeing broken glass **after being asked** if they saw broken glass — even if none was actually present.

This means that when you and your partner argue about "what really happened," neither of you is *lying* — you're just **remembering different versions of reality**.

How the Brain Creates Your Internal Representation of Reality

Our internal representation of reality is shaped by filters — the ways we process and interpret the world. Here are the key players in the brain that shape this process:

Prediction runs the show.



The Mechanism

- The brain reduces complexity to protect certainty.
- When conflict activates, perception narrows.
- You stop responding to what is happening and start responding to what you expect will happen.
- The hippocampus reconstructs possible scenes from stored fragments and hands them to the brain as forecasts.

1. The Amygdala (Emotional Alarm System)

The amygdala assigns emotional significance to experiences. If something reminds you of past pain, your brain will filter that event through the lens of threat — even if no real threat exists.

Example: If your last partner cheated and your current partner is texting someone, your amygdala might hijack your response and trigger anxiety, suspicion, or anger, even if there's no actual betrayal.

2. The Prefrontal Cortex (Rational Thought)

This is the part of the brain that evaluates information, regulates emotions, and applies logic. However, it often plays catch-up to the amygdala, meaning we feel first and think later.

Example: You might snap at your partner before realizing their late text wasn't personal — it was just bad timing.

3. The Default Mode Network (DMN) & Storytelling Brain

The DMN is responsible for mind-wandering, daydreaming, and creating narratives about our experiences. It fills in gaps with assumptions, so if your partner is distant, your brain might automatically create a story that they're mad at you — even if they're just tired.

These brain systems work together to shape your internal map, which determines your emotional state, behavior, and ultimately, your lived experience.

Practical Examples: How This Plays Out in Relationships

1. The Forgotten Anniversary

Territory (Objective Reality): Your partner forgot your anniversary dinner plans.

Your Map:

- **Mind:** Your attention locks onto the missed date. Past experiences of feeling unimportant surface.
- **Attribution:** “They don’t care about me.”
- **Perspective:** You were already feeling under-appreciated.
- **Sentiment:** Underneath the anger, grief — the ache of not being prioritized.
- **Story:** “I’m in a one-sided relationship.”

Reality Check — Your partner’s map might look totally different:

- **Mind:** Their attention was consumed by work pressure. The date slipped entirely.
- **Attribution:** They assume you know they love you, even if they forget dates.
- **Perspective:** They’re mentally drained and assumed things were fine between you.
- **Sentiment:** Guilt and a low hum of shame when they realize.
- **Story:** “I feel bad, but I wish they’d understand how much is on my plate.”

The fight isn’t about the anniversary — it’s about how your maps interpret the meaning of forgetting.

2. “You Never Listen to Me”

Territory (Objective Reality): Your partner checked their phone while you were talking.

Your Map:

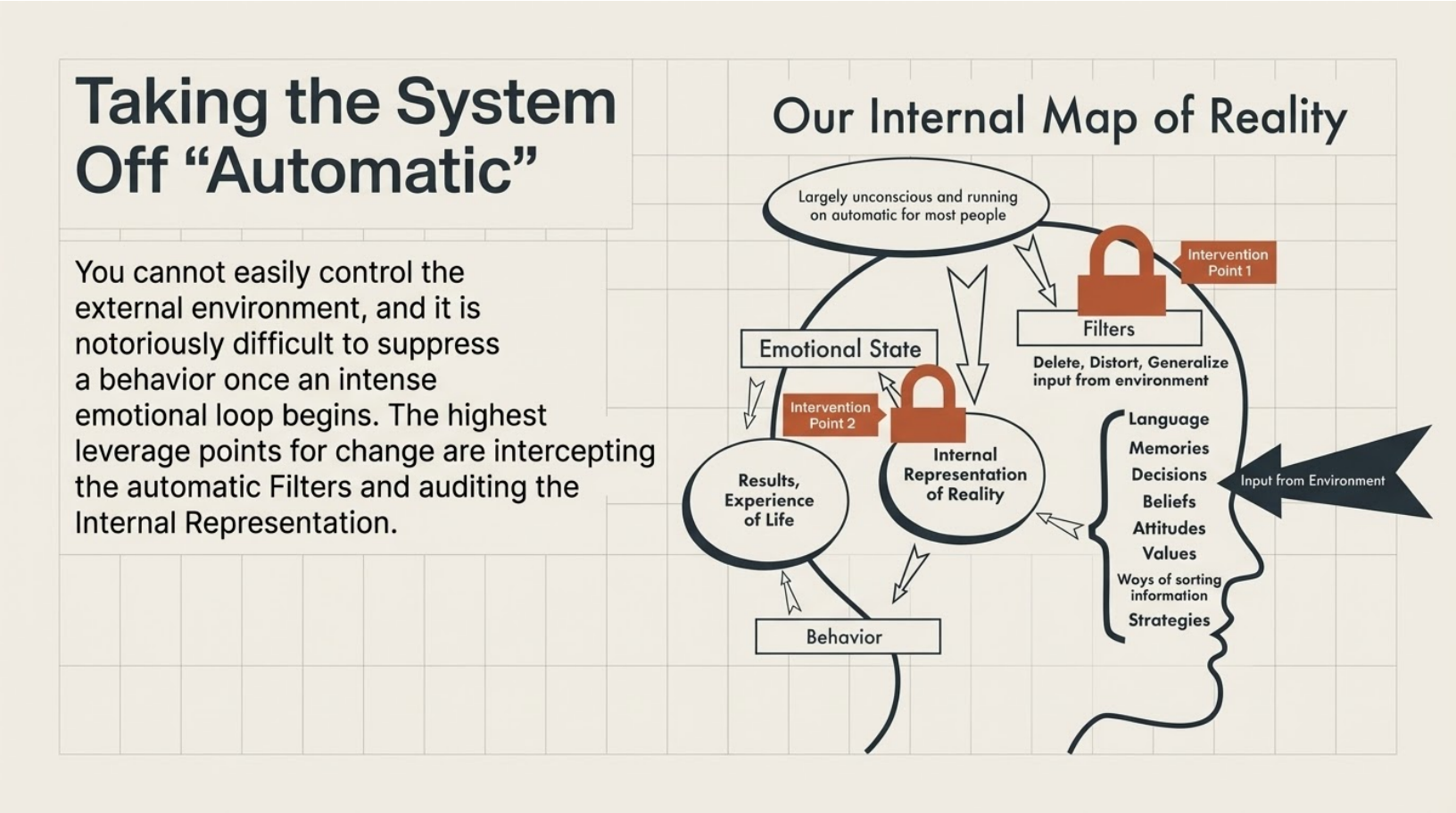
- **Mind:** Your attention locks onto the phone. Past moments of feeling unseen surface.
- **Attribution:** “They don’t respect me.”
- **Perspective:** You were already feeling unimportant in the relationship.
- **Sentiment:** Underneath the irritation, loneliness.
- **Story:** “They don’t care about what I have to say.”

Reality Check — Your partner's map:

- **Mind:** Their attention flickered to a work email out of habit.
- **Attribution:** "I can listen and check this at the same time."
- **Perspective:** They assume things are fine and don't see this as dismissive.
- **Sentiment:** Confusion sliding into defensiveness when your reaction lands.
- **Story:** "They always assume the worst about me."

This argument happens because your brain fi lled in gaps with assumptions, turning a moment of distraction into a sign of deeper relationship failure.

How to Apply This Understanding in Your Relationship



You cannot easily control the external environment, and it is notoriously dif fi cult to suppress a behavior once an intense emotional loop begins. The highest leverage points for change are intercepting the automatic Filters and auditing the Internal Representation.

1. **Assume your map is incomplete.** Instead of reacting as if your interpretation is the truth, pause and ask, "What else could be true?"

2. **Check for memory distortion.** If you and your partner remember something differently, ask, "How might our emotions be shaping our memories?"

3. **Communicate your MAPSS.** Instead of accusing, share your experience:

- “When this happened, my mind went to a place of feeling unimportant.”
- “I know this might not have been your intention, but here’s the story my brain told me.”

4. **Ask about their map.** Instead of assuming bad intent, ask:

- “What was your experience of this?”
- “Can you help me understand what you were thinking when that happened?”

Communicating With MAPSS in Mind

So how do you use this in your relationship?

1. **Pause and check your map.** Ask yourself:

- What am I assuming right now?
- What meaning am I assigning to this?
- Is there another possible explanation?
- What feeling is running underneath the one I’m showing?

2. **Hold your map with humility.** Instead of assuming you know what your partner meant, approach with openness:

- “Hey, I noticed I got upset when you didn’t text back. My brain went to a story that you didn’t care. Can you help me understand what was happening on your end?”

3. **Listen with curiosity to your partner’s map.** Instead of defending your perspective, ask:

- “What was your experience of this?”
- “What was going through your mind when that happened?”

4. **Make room for multiple truths.** Both of your maps can exist at the same time. You don’t have to agree — just understand.

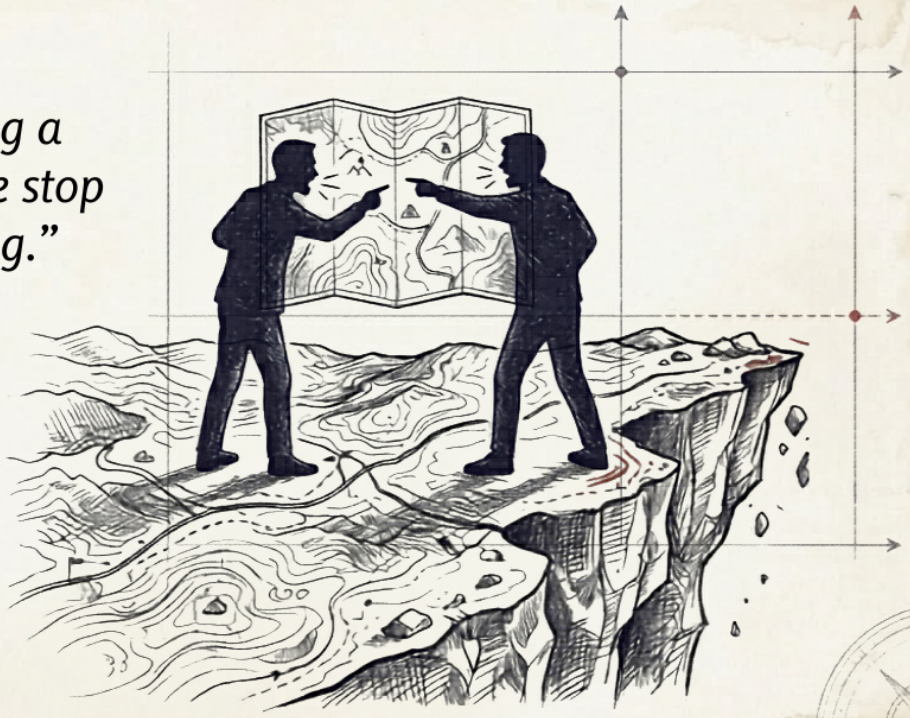
The Core Error

“When we forget we’re using a map, we stop exploring. We stop learning. We start defending.”

A tightly held bias is often an efficient way of *not* wanting to know the truth.

Most conflict doesn't come from people having different maps; it comes from mistaking those maps for the territory itself.

When this happens, disagreement feels like an attack on reality.



The Real Goal: Connection, Not Winning

Couples who get stuck in who’s right and who’s wrong miss the bigger picture. The goal of communication isn’t to win — it’s to understand. To connect. Connection is always the solution.

When you stop arguing over maps and start exploring them with each other, you create space for empathy, trust, and connection.

You are never reacting to what happened. You are reacting to your map of what happened. And the moment you see that, you can stop defending the map long enough to let your partner in.